

MUZZLE-LOADING ARTILLERY

Despite having been the earliest form of gunpowder weapon, muzzle-loading artillery remained a potent force until the very last years of the 19th century. Strong and mechanically uncomplicated smoothbore weapons, these muzzle-loaders fired round shot made of lead or iron. In the late 1850s, muzzle-loading artillery began to evolve into refined rifled steel weapons able to fire aerodynamic projectiles—huge shells capable of penetrating the thickest armor plate.

▼ INDIAN BRONZE 24-POUNDER GUN

Date Late 18th century
Origin India
Length 10¾ft (3.27m)
Caliber 5.66in (142.2mm)
Range Just over 1 mile (1.8km)

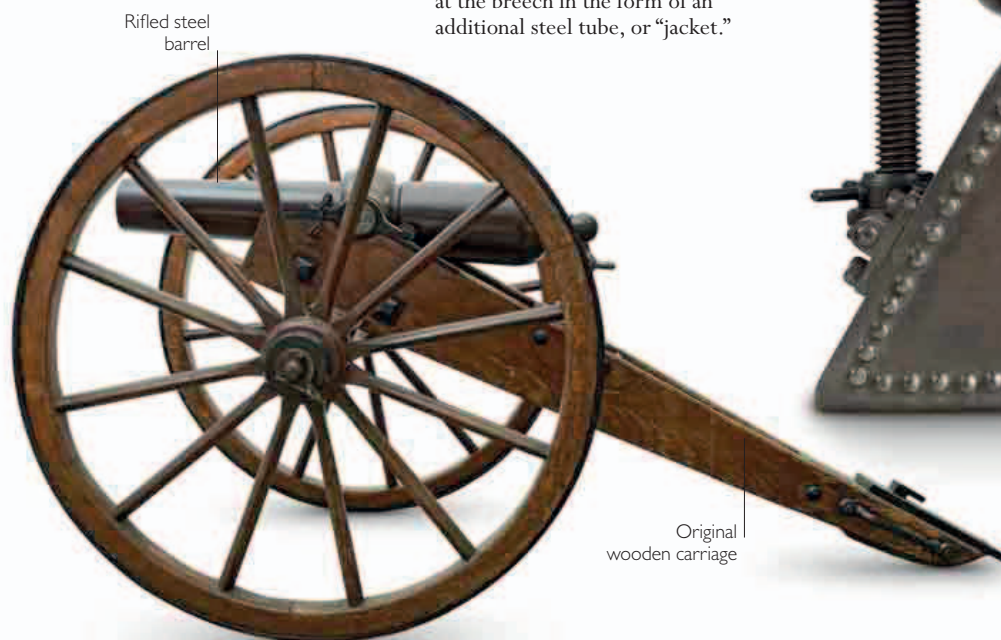
This gun barrel represents the many older pieces kept in regular and effective use in many parts of the world well into the 19th century. It is decorated on the muzzle and barrel with motifs resembling tiger's stripes. Tigers' heads also form the muzzle, the cascable button, and the ends of the trunnions.



▼ BLAKELY 2.75-IN RML MOUNTAIN GUN

Date 1865
Origin UK
Length (Barrel) 3¾ft (1m)
Caliber 2.75in (69.85mm)
Range Just over 1 mile (1.8km)

In mountainous terrain, armies required lighter, more maneuverable field guns, and mountain guns were developed to meet this need. This rifled muzzle-loader, or RML gun, manufactured by the innovative Blakely Ordnance Company, has a steel barrel with six-groove rifling and reinforcement at the breech in the form of an additional steel tube, or "jacket."



▲ CHINESE 32-POUNDER

Date 1841
Origin China
Length 9ft (2.74m)
Caliber 7.5in (190mm)
Range Just over 1 mile (1.8km)

Engravings on the breech indicate that this imposing bronze 32-pounder was cast in August 1841, during the reign of Chinese Emperor Daoguang (1820–50), for coastal defense duties.

Decorative molded bands on smoothbore barrel

